DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Is the World Getting Better?

Daat Tevunot §48

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §48 (continued)
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 1 December 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Last class completed the warning that we only ever speak of how God manifests Himself to us, never His essence, and began the period of concealment of yihud Hashem. In this period God allows bad to exist so that there is choice, and because there is choice, there is evil. Today's section adds two things: God is still at work within the concealment, and beneath it all an overarching plan is driving the world toward the revelation of His unity.

A shadow of the real light

Even though God has hidden His goodness and we are no longer perfect, He constantly gives us the energy to exist; without it nothing could exist for a moment. But compared to what it would be in a perfect world, this flow is like a person's shadow compared to the person, or like the faint marks left on a page after you rub out pencil letters. Relative to the real flow, it is called darkness. It is light, or we could not exist, but it is like a very dim room that we call dark: there is light, just far less than there should be. This is the energy we live with in the concealment phase.

A participant asked whether this is the light God hid after the sin, to be restored with Mashiah. The Rabbi said no. Even when the world was created we were not perfect, and if this were that light there would be no room for sin. It is a different light, a light of insight, which is intensified at certain times, which is why we feel a spiritual high on festivals and holy days. "But it's still nothing compared to the real thing. You can still sin on Yom Kippur."

The concealment exists for the revelation

The Ramhal continues: since the ultimate intention is the revelation of His unity, and not its concealment, and the concealment exists only to reach that end, then even while He hides His face, God in His greatness and authority directs a hanhagah of goodness toward what the Ramhal calls the "tikkun hakelali," the complete rectification. The Rabbi noted, with a smile, that this is not the Tikkun HaKelali of Rabbi Nahman of Breslov, the ten psalms. Here it means the final, complete rectification that will bring about yihud Hashem, a phrase the Ramhal will use often.

This world exists for 6,000 years, and God decided from the start that its end is the revelation of His unity and eternal good for us. So every day that passes, the world comes closer to its perfection. God does not want bad to go on for a long time and then suddenly switch, like someone who changes his mind. In His wisdom He turns things around from within the good and bad themselves, so that they arrive at the complete perfection, and so that no one is lost. "Oh how beautiful," the Rabbi said. The change is not instant, from concealment one second to revelation the next. Within the hester there is a constant drive, galgulim, God turning events toward the end.

Is the world really getting better?

The Rabbi said he believes this is visible in our days, with many things returning to how they once were. People say every generation is worse than the last, but the Ramhal here says the world as a whole becomes more perfect with every generation. Much of what people think is new is old. Immorality existed among the Greeks and Romans; the difference today is that people want you to believe it is normal.

The group debated this: - A participant argued that since less work remains before 6,000, later generations need not be on as high a level. The Rabbi asked why less work should mean a lower spiritual level, and said the paragraph does not necessarily contradict "yeridat hadorot," the decline of the generations. Individuals may be lower and less able to accomplish things, but the world as a whole is getting better. - Another participant felt the world is becoming more immoral and more exposed. The Rabbi pointed out how much idolatry there was 2,000 years ago compared to today. He cited the Rambam, who writes that Christianity and Islam are paving the way, because more people now believe in one God. Christian belief in unity is different and is heresy for us, but it is still belief in one God rather than many. "It's quite encouraging."

Two systems at once

The Ramhal now ties this together with what the group learnt in Derech Hashem: God runs the world with two things. - **Hanhagat hamishpat, the system of justice:** reward and punishment, good and evil, consequences measure for measure. This is what we normally see. God, as it were, has bound Himself to it. He does not want to punish us, but there are consequences. When we do His will we "give Him strength," as in "tenu oz lElokim"; when we do wrong we "weaken" Him, as in "Sur yeladekha teshi." This does not mean we make God strong or weak. It means He has limited Himself to a system in which He must bring consequences, like a father who loves his son but has to punish him for breaking the rules of the house. - **Hanhagat hayihud, the system in the background:** His full authority, constantly working to return everything to good and to bring the world to its complete perfection. Here the prophets say "I will remove the sin of that land in one day," and "the sin of Israel will be sought, and there will be none." Even when He seems to have bound Himself, He remains in control, and at any moment He can say, "I still love you."

What we see constantly is reward and punishment. The background system is very deep and will only be seen at the end, but it is always there. The two are intertwined, which is why the world will not change from one day to the next. A participant summed it up: because God can

intensify the background system whenever He wants, history follows a smooth curve rather than a sudden jump. "Exactly," said the Rabbi. He found it fascinating that Derech Hashem's teaching on the two hanhagot now appears at a deeper level, rooted in the tikkun of the world.

Summary

- Even during the concealment God sustains the world, but with a "shadow" of His true light; festivals intensify that light without removing free choice.
- The concealment exists only for the revelation, so within it God steers everything toward the tikkun hakelali.
- The change is gradual: every day brings the world closer to perfection, even if individuals and generations may decline.
- Hanhagat hamishpat (justice and consequences) is what we see; hanhagat hayihud works constantly in the background and can override it.
- Their interweaving lets history move smoothly toward the revelation of God's unity.

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